THE ROYAL BRITISH LEGION
PARIS BRANCH

ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING 2012

FOR YEAR 1st OCTOBER 2011 – 30TH SEPTEMBER 2012

The Paris Branch Annual General Meeting was held at 28, rue des Acacias, 75017 Paris, on Monday 19th November, 2012 at 18h30. The Chairman, Mr. R. Thorn, invited all members to stand for the Exhortation and Silent Tribute and to remember Pamela Hastings, Rosemary Bateau-Clubb and former Vice-Chairman, Jack Wicker.

There were 27 members present with three guests, which included Mr. John Crothers, Organist of the combined Choir of the various British Churches in Paris, Mr. Andrew Holford, Concert Trumpeter and Mr. John Greenwood, Auditor of the Paris Branch. The Chairman welcomed them all.

Apologies for Absence : Apologies were received from Mesdames Bean, Burkard, Hicks, Mann, Thourot and Zomerplaag and from Messrs. Auduc, Baker, Corrigan, Gould, Liberman, Maloubier, G. Morris, S. Morris, Peridi, G. Warby, R. Warby, Weatherlake and Zomerplaag. We had received 11 proxy votes from amongst these members.

Minutes of the Previous A.G.M. : The Chairman asked if the minutes of the 8th December, 2011 AGM could be accepted as a true record, signed and dated. This was agreed with no matters arising. These minutes were proposed by Mr. C. Spencer-Bernard and seconded by Mr. G. Scott.

Chairman's Report : The Chairman said that our year had been dominated by the death in September of our former Vice-Chairman and friend, Jack Wicker. He will be greatly missed as will the two ladies mentioned earlier in this report.

The Chairman said he would like to welcome as well as the three gentlemen mention above, The Rev. Robert Varty from Caen.

Welfare : Welfare will always be our Raison d'être. David bean will report later on Welfare activities during the past year. We continue to contribute to the British Charitable Fund, a procedure which has been authorized by RBL London following an Internal Audit conducted in 1999, when the internal auditor from London met with the BCF and saw how the Poppy funds were being appropriately applied in meeting the needs of our eligible candidates. This approval is sought and given every year. This year we contributed 10,500€, 500€ more than in recent years, following another successful Poppy Appeal Campaign. Our beneficiaries receive allowances totaling approximately 4 times that amount, so representing a very satisfactory gearing. Every year the BCF send us a statement of the monies received by our names candidates. I would like to thank Charles Spencer-Bernard who has joined our Welfare team. We now have four Branch members who are qualified caseworkers. Thanks also to our case-workers, Elizabeth and David Bean.

Poppy Appeal : Since the AGM is one month earlier than was usual in the past we do not yet have complete results of this year's Poppy Appeal. I would like to thank Miss Gilhooley and her helpers to date, Janet Warby and George Mutch.

Ceremonies since the last A.G.M. : Our principal Annual Ceremonies are the Ravivage de La Flamme, 4th August. This year it was the turn of the Australians to be our guests and the Ambassador, Mr. Ric Wells, did the honours of lighting the flame. This was followed by a Reception in the Clubhouse.

Notre Dame 2012 saw an exceptionally high turnout for the Service of Remembrance. We thank our Chaplain, Canon Philip Mounstephen for his Order of Service, and for giving the sermon. Canon Mounstephen came back specially for this Service, having already left his post as Chaplain of St. Michael's, Paris to become the new Director of the Church Missionary Society, based in Oxford. We give warm thanks for his dedication to the affairs of the RBL Paris Branch. His wife Ruth told me that Philip was very moved and motivated by what he was of the work and ethos of the RBL. So his dedication was his way of thanking us for that experience. We did not manage to secure the services of our star cornet player, L/Cpl Robert Parry, Coldstream Guards, because he was on duty that day at the Cenotaph. Instead we found talent close to hand in Andrew Holford, a member of the RAFA, who is a concert trumpeter. But this time he didn't blow his own trumpet, but wrote to Aldershot to buy an Army bugle, with cord. This he played to perfection. He said he had started to play the bugle as a schoolboy of eight, and later in his CCF band. Our usual piper and Branch member Murdoch McCleod played the pipes for us with his usual panache, having flown in from Edinburgh.

We would wish to have our Service filmed another year, but sponsorship will be required to be in a position to pay a film company. Warm thanks to Canon Philip Mounstephen, Roger and Janet Warby, Chief Usher David Bean, the Choir and Organist John Crothers.

Other Ceremonies : February 11th saw us at the annual ceremony at Bennecourt, which is twinned with Coldstream. The Branch was represented by Maire Didier Dumont, the Chairman, Joseph and Françoise Sigward and Lt. Pierre Quenot. A detachment of the Coldstream Guards took part.

April 22nd saw us at Maisons-Laffitte for the annual ceremony at the RAF Memorial in the Park. The Branch was represented by Jack Wicker, David and Elizabeth Bean, Roger and Janet Warby.

In May David and Elizabeth Bean, Noreen and Jacques Riols, Bob Maloubier and Joseph and Françoise Sigward represented the Paris Branch at the Annual S.O.E., Ceremony at Valençay.

On 25th August the Chairman represented the Branch and his Regiment at the Ceremonies at and near Vernon (Eure) to commemorate the Liberation of the town on that date in 1944 by 6 Infantry county regiments, the 1st Worcesters, the 4th Somerset Light Infantry, the 4th and 5th Wiltshires, and the 5th Cornwall Light Infantry.

On 2nd September the Paris branch was represented at the Annual cycle rally Pedal to Paris, culminating in the laying of Poppy Wreath at the Tomb of the Unknown Soldier. We learnt that this event raises £500,000 for the Poppy Appeal. John Farmer, RBL National Chairman laid the wreath.

On 25th September, jointly with the Paris Branch of the RNVRA we attended a ceremony at the graveside of Admiral Sir Bertram Ramsay in Saint Germain-en-Laye Old Cemetery.

Funeral of Jack Wicker, OBE : The Paris Branch was well represented at the Funeral of Jack Wicker at Holy Trinity Church, Maisons-Laffitte on 1st October. We thank Janet and Roger Warby for carrying the Union Flag and branch standard.

The Chairman attended a Service of Remembrance at The British School of Paris and addressed the school on the origins and work of the RBL and on the story of the Poppy.

The Battlefield Visit this year was to Arnhem on 19th – 21st October, once more under the guidance of Colonel Oliver Warman, late Welsh Guards. It has been suggested that the 2013 tour take place at Dunkirk. A large number of Welsh Guardsmen are buried in the cemetery at Boulogne-sur-Mer, where related fighting also took place.

Membership : Paris branch membership numbers, having drifted downwards in recent years, have now stabilized since 2010. We are determined to concentrate on drumming up additional members here in Paris, where we judge there is a fund of good-will towards us in the British Community. Mailing cost of Branch papers to members are naturally high, and we continue to use e-mail to communicate with members who are electronically connected; that percentage of e-members is now over 60% and rising. Our thanks to Mark Yates for his many hours of administration and for his skillful work as our Webmaster.

Social events in the RBL year : We held our Christmas lunch on 16th December, 2011, the Christmas Mess Night was held on 18th December, 2011.

The Poppy 'Thank You', Standard Bearers' and New Members' Cocktail was held on 7th March, 2012

On 6th November, 2012, Les Clack, Trish Kessler and Chloe Dunn gave War Poetry readings

The Annual Poppy Coffee Morning was held in the Ambassador's Residence on 8th November 2012. Lady Ricketts was our hostess. We would like to thank Lady Ricketts, Joan Hicks, Janet Warby, Carmen Thourot, Vicky Millett and David Bean for organising this event.

Co-propriété : Thanks to the late Jack Wicker for representing us most effectively on the Co-Propriété Committee both in rue Boudreau and now in rue des Acacias. Charles Spencer-Bernard has kindly agreed to represent us in future. Thank you Charles.

House Manager : Monthly lunches recommenced in 2010 with a wide range of cuisine, and we thank Tony Bennett warmly for catering for those lunches. We have received a donation in the form of a T.V. set and we will consider organizing film evenings in the New Year, and we will also establish whether International Rugby afternoons can be organized with Paris Welsh and Caledonian Societies. I would also like to thank Ben Galang for the help he gives to Tony and for his devoted attention to the cleaning of our premises.

Fund-raising : The Sweepstakes and Tombola will be reported on in the Treasurer's report later. I just wanted to say here how grateful we are to members for their faithful support which the Treasurer appreciates enormously. Thank you therefore to all the members who support us in this way.

Relations with the British Embassy : The Ambassador is our Patron in France, H.M. The Queen, of course remaining our Royal Patron. Many thanks to Sir Peter Ricketts, Air Commodore John Maas and Wing Commander Graham August for their continued support. I am writing to Sir Peter and Lad Ricketts to thank them for their ready support of the RBL since their arrival in Paris. The good news is that a new Military Attaché is already in post, and will take up his duties shortly upon completion of his training. His is Colonel James Murray-Playfair, former C.O. of the 2nd Battalion, The Royal Regiment of Fusiliers. His last post was also in Paris as the Senior British Liaison Officer to the French Etat-Major de l'Armée de Terre.

Branch Committee : Many thanks to our hard-working officers and committee. I don't know if you realize how many hours of voluntary work are put in by our Secretary and Treasurer, and without them this branch would grind to a halt. Could I invite you to show your appreciation in the usual way. I would draw your attention in particular to the enormous work-load shouldered by our Secretary and by our Social Secretary, Joan Hicks. David Blanchard started the year as Acting Treasurer. Last year you paid him a warm tribute for his 21 years as Treasurer, and for his enormous assistance to the Secretary and to myself. Imagine now how delighted we are to welcome his co-opted successor Ian McDonald to his first AGM. Not only has he had to learn the ropes from zero, but he has had to prepare his accounts one month earlier than we have had to in the past. This put added strain on him, but as you will have seen he has met his deadline and we thank him warmly.

We note that long-time Committee members Ken Davey and David Edwards are not standing this year. May I thank them warmly on your behalf for their devoted service to the branch and to the Legion. Ken is now incapacitated and can no longer get around. David spends a large part of the year out of the country and he is generously making way for some keen volunteers who are standing for election later in our AGM. Thanks therefore must go to Ken Davey and David Edwards for their past services and to Jon Cooper, Peter Huggins, Stephen Parry and James Weatherlake for agreeing to stand.

The future : In 2013 the Paris Branch and The Royal British Legion celebrated the 60th Anniversary of the Coronation of our Royal Patron, H.M. The Queen. Your Committee is planning a Commonwealth Celebratory Cocktail at the Ecole Militaire in June, and this event is booked for Friday 14th June 2013. H.M. British Ambassador, our Patron in France, has already accepted our invitation to be our main guest, and we now intend to invite the Commonwealth ambassadors and service attachés.

As members will recall I reported at the last AGM that The Royal British Legion in London had wished to see a District set up in France. In Legion-speak this meant the equivalent of a County Committee in the UK. In the event there was not a majority of the French Branches in favour of this proposal, and the plan was dropped. I can report that to date there has been no follow-up by London to the original proposal.

At the Business schools we teach students to carry out a first analysis of a company's health by identifying its current Strengths and Weaknesses, and the Opportunities and the Threats for the future. If we do this for RBL Paris Branch we could draw up the following lists :

Our Strengths are :

- That we have a very loyal membership,
- We have a very motivated management team on the Committee
- We have our own well-situated premises, whose purchase was financed by the
- Sale of the premises in rue Boudreau. The Clubhouse at the latter address was a
- Far-sighted original investment by our predecessors in 1953.
- The disposal of Boudreau and the purchase of Acacias left us with a capital surplus, Which is currently invested.
- With the aid of our subscription income, donations, rental income, Tombolas and Sweepstakes we balance our books on current account.
- The RBL and its Poppy has a strong brand image. Flowing from that there is a fund of good-will among the British community in Paris; the Notre Dame Service of Remembrance is packed every year without any publicity.

Our Weakness is :

- Principally demographic, as is true of the RBL as a whole. The average age of our Membership is probably nearer 70 than 60. We have representatives of the Second World War veterans and of the National Service generation, but for many

reasons the next generation of both servicemen and civilians is not well represented.

Opportunities :

- Our strengths present us with opportunities, and the challenge is to try to eliminate our weakness by bridging the generation gap. That means a rethink of our attractiveness to the younger generation, which almost certainly means a development of activities designed to do precisely that. We have cheaper beer than the pubs for example.

The Threats :

- Principally are that we do not find a solution to the generation gap.
- That our share of the Welfare provision in France continues to dwindle in the face of SSAFA whose approach may be described as that of a network of special forces whose activities are orchestrated, but since they have no permanent structure they have no fixed costs. With many troops on the ground, they often operate in areas not covered by the RBL branches. Perhaps with our fellow RBL branches we should examine whether we are sufficiently pro-active in making our services known.

Finally a word about the nature of British clubs and of the Royal British Legion in particular. The RBL brings so many different people together in a common cause. Whether you were a Brigadier or a Bombardier, an Air Commodore or an Aircraftsman, a Ship's Captain or a Ship's Cook, everyone mucks in to do the job in hand. It is that fellowship which makes a club, and I hope the Paris Branch will maintain that fine tradition. There was an echo of this leveling when we saw that Admiral Ramsay was buried alongside the members of the crew flying his plane to Brussels.

Thank you for your attention.

Treasurer's Report : The Treasurer said he was pleased to present, for the first time, the annual accounts for our financial year ended September 30, 2012. But before doing so he would like to officially record his thanks to Mr. David Blanchard, the outgoing Treasurer. The Paris Branch has been very fortunate to have been able to count on the services of a professional such as David Blanchard and this will be a hard act to follow. He said he would also like to thank Mr. Blanchard for all his time and patience in handing over the role of Treasurer to him, both in the day to day running of the financial affairs of the branch and in the preparation of these accounts.

Administration Fund :

Income : This year our operating expenditure exceeded our income by €767, an improvement on last year when our expenditure exceeded income from operations by €1,652.

Net fund raising income was stable (-€102) with good increases in subscriptions, donations and tombola being offset by decreases in sweepstakes and social events.

There was a reduction of €987 in our total cost of recurring operations compared to last year, mainly due to decreased reception costs of €2,072, (last year the figure included the 90th anniversary celebrations), although this was offset by cost increases in several categories, most notably premises costs which went up by €679.

Balance Sheet : Our net assets stand at €548,044 and the Administration Fund cash position is €37,690. We still have a healthy balance on deposit at the bank.

Poppy Appeal Fund : Donations and poppy sales were up by nearly €3,000 over last year, an increase of nearly 22%. Relief payments made to the British Charitable Fund were €10,500 and other welfare payments totaled €694. Provision had been made for a further payment of €2,500 which will be made shortly to the British Charitable Fund.

We show a net excess of income over outgoings for the year of €2,446 and the Poppy Appeal Fund cash position stands at €10,243

Audit : The accounts as presented to the meeting have been audited.

The Chairman thanked Mr. McDonald for his report and asked the floor for any questions. There being none the Chairman asked for the Financial Statement to be proposed and seconded. The report was proposed by Mr. G. Scott and seconded by Mr. D. Bean.

The Chairman said he would like to thank Mr. John Greenwood in this his first Audit of our accounts. The Auditor said the branch was well set up for the future.

Welfare Report : Mr. Bean reported that this had been a quiet year. We have two ongoing cases and at present have four Welfare Caseworkers. Mr. Bean said it is good that it has been quiet but we must not become complacent. Mr. Bean said he would also like to thank the British Charitable Fund for their help. Mr. Bean said that he had been approached by RBL London to become a Training Officer for the branches in France, Belgium and Holland. Mr. Bean had recently conducted training sessions in Brittany and Poitou-Charente areas. Every Caseworker has to re-train every two years by law. The Chairman thanked Mr. Bean for his report.

Election of Officers & Committee : The Chairman said that Mr. O.G. Longley, had agreed to serve as our Hon. President for the next year. The Chairman asked Mr. Longley if he would like to announce the names of the Officers and Committee who had agreed to stand once more. Mr. Longley said the nominations for Officers were :

Chairman	Roger Thorn
Vice-Chairman	David Bean
Hon. Treasurer	Ian McDonald
Hon. Secretary	Janet Warby

The following were elected to the Committee : Miss J. Hicks, Mme. N. Riols, Miss V. Millet, Messrs. Bennett, Blanchard, Cockle, Cooper, Dumont, Gould, Huggins, Parry, Spencer-Bernard, Weatherlake and Yates

The following are invited to become ex-Officio Members on our Committee : Col. D. Jacir, ANAP, Mr. G. Scott, RAFA, Mme. G. Corrigan, 40/8 Society and Mme. P. Levalleur, Free French.

The Officers were voted into office and the Committee were elected en bloc. The nominations were proposed by Mr. D. Edwards and Baron R. Gillespie. The Chairman said the next Committee Meeting would be held on Thursday 17th January 2013.

Any Other Business : Miss Gilhooley asked the Chairman if the Charity Ceilidh would be going ahead. The Chairman confirmed it would be to which Miss Gilhooley said that the Committee needed to help. The Ceilidh would be held on Friday 7th December at St. Michael's Church hall.

The Chairman mentioned that Mr. Longley and Mr. Scott had books on sale at the moment. Mr. Longley's is about his life before, during and after the Second World War, the title of Mr. Longley's book is 'To Hell with that!' Mr. Scott's book is called Remembrance. It has some beautiful colour 'photo's and some are from Camp Bastian in Afghanistan. Some of the 'photo's are of Mr. Scott's own family. There is soon to be a paperback version out. The profits from Mr. Longley's book will be devided between the British Hospital in Paris and The Royal British Legion, Paris Branch. The profits from Mr. Scott's book will be devided between the RBL Paris Branch and RAFA Ile de France Branch.

Mme. Corrigan gave a short report on the activities of the 40/8 Society and the former Chess Section.

Mr. Edwards asked what the relationship between SAAFA and the RBL was. The Chairman and Mr. Bean said that there is no integration between the two and we do not have any problems. There are also a couple of other Charitable organizations that we sometimes work with and these are The Elizabeth Finn and Officers Associations.

Mr. Longley said he would like to thank the Chairman for maintaining a tight ship.

Mr. Riols asked if it would be possible to have a copy of the Branch membership list sent to each member for reference, Mr. Yates replied that this might contravene the Data Protection Act and therefore we would not be happy in doing this.

There being no further business, the meeting was closed at 19h47.